

FAMILY FEUD

Shakespeare's best-known early tragedy is *Romeo and Juliet*. The play tells the story of two young lovers who are kept apart by a bitter feud between their families. It takes the tragic deaths of the lovers to bring the feud to an end.



The famous tragedies

IN THE 1590s, SHAKESPEARE wrote only a few tragedies, concentrating on comedies and history plays. He returned to the form in the early 1600s, when he wrote *Hamlet*, *King Lear*, *Othello*, and *Macbeth* – plays that provided his star Richard Burbage with his greatest roles. This group of tragedies contains Shakespeare's most famous poetry, such as Prince Hamlet's soliloquies on the meaning of life. There are also exciting action scenes, such as the fencing duel at the end of *Hamlet*. The prince does not know that his opponent Laertes has a poisoned sword and means to kill him.

Hamlet thrusts at Laertes's right shoulder, scoring a hit

Laertes tries to stab Hamlet, who deflects the blow

Laertes defends himself against Hamlet

Hamlet is the better swordsman

Hamlet thrusts at Laertes's thigh

Laertes catches Hamlet off guard and cuts him with his poisoned sword – it will be his death blow

FIT FOR FIGHTING

Players had to be skilled at sword fighting. Gentlemen learned fencing as part of their education and wore swords with their everyday dress. So, if they saw clumsy fighting in a play, they would boo the players off the stage. Fencing matches were also a popular entertainment. They were often put on as sporting events in the playhouses.

DEADLY DUEL

Hamlet believes that his duel with Laertes is a friendly contest. But the play's villain, Claudius, has persuaded Laertes to kill Hamlet. In the duel, Laertes and Hamlet are both wounded by the poisoned sword. The dying Laertes then confesses to Hamlet, who uses the sword to kill Claudius before he dies himself. At the play's end, the stage is covered with dead bodies.



STREET FIGHTING
Shakespeare wrote sword fights into several of his plays. In *Romeo and Juliet*, Romeo's friend Mercutio fights Juliet's cousin Tybalt in a street brawl.